> Then I saw a party of about twenty men drawn up in my road, who when I came near, began picking up large stones . . . so I with difficulty put my pony into a gallop and, taking the bridle in my mouth, cut right and left with my sword as I went through them. They could not reach me with their knives and I was only hit by one or two stones. A little further on I was met by another similar party who I tried to pass as I did the former, but was obliged to prick the poor pony with the point of my sword before I could get him into a gallop. Of this party, one man on a mound over the road had a gun, which he fired close down upon me, and broke my sword, leaving only about six inches on the handle.

Brydon managed to get clear of these attackers, only to find that ‘the shot had hit the poor pony, wounding him in the loins, and he could now hardly carry me’.

> Then I saw some five horsemen dressed in red, and supposing they were some of our irregular cavalry, I made towards them, but, getting near, found they were Afghans, and that they were leading Captain Collyer’s horse. I tried to get away, but my pony could hardly move, and they sent one of their party after me, who made a cut at me, guarding against which with the bit of my sword, it fell from the hilt. He passed me, but turned and rode at me again. This time, just as he was striking, I threw the handle of the sword at his head, in swerving to avoid which he only cut me over the back of the left hand. Feeling it disabled, I stretched down the right to pick up the bridle. I suppose my foe thought it was for a pistol, for he turned at once and made off as quick as he could. I then felt for the pistol I had put in my pocket, but it was gone, and I was unarmed, and on a poor animal I feared could not carry me to Jalalabad.

The surgeon felt suddenly drained of energy: ‘I became nervous and frightened at shadows, and I really think would have fallen from my saddle but for the peak of it?. . .’ He had been spotted, however, by an eagle-eyed staff officer on the top turret of the Jalalabad fort, and rescuers quickly came to his assistance.

> Among the first of them was Captain Sinclair, whose servant gave me one of his own shoes to cover my foot. I was taken to the Sappers’ Mess, my wounds dressed by Dr Forsyth, and after a good dinner, with great thankfulness, enjoyed the luxury of a sound sleep . . . On examination I found that I had a slight sword wound on my left knee, besides my head and left hand, and that a ball had gone through my trousers a little higher up, slightly grazing the skin . . . The poor pony, directly it was put into a stable, lay down and never rose again. Immediately on my telling how things were, General Sale despatched a party to scour the plains . . . but they only found the bodies of Captain Hopkins and Collyer, and Dr Harper . . .[64]

That night, lamps were raised on the gates of Jalalabad and bugles blown to guide in any last stragglers, but none limped in. ‘A strong wind was blowing from the south, which sent the sound of the bugles all over the